

FOREWORD

Fashion offers a dialogue rich with social and political meaning for those who want to unlock the language of clothes. And there is much to be learned by exploring human relationships with finery. Way beyond functions of protection and warmth, we recognise the power of clothes to proclaim or augment individual and collective identity. In fact, our need to adorn our bodies – to dress up and express something of ourselves whilst embracing visual codes in order to stand out from the crowd or blend in with the pack – is so strong, that today's UK fashion industry is worth an estimated £32 billion.

The wearing of fine garments can embolden us and, unlike in the past, today's accessible pricing offers a democratic platform for wearers. But in recent years the experience of fashion and style has been accompanied by the "Brand" imperative, which seeks to conquer and possess pliant consumer will. Need has been converted to want and we find our love of embellishment corrupted by an acceleration in turnover of short-lived trends and persistent calls to purchase. Now our perception of ourselves is influenced by a proliferation of marketing messages with subtle, and not so subtle, pointers on "the right way to be". So we tailor our bodies to fit mass-market sizes, overstock our wardrobes, and replenish our supply of fast-fashion fixes, while instinctively recognising that clothes have the psychological power to elevate our sense of self. As a vehicle for social acceptance, relevance, or visibility the narrative of fashion has always had currency. But, when the average teenager is shown more images of unachievable beauty in one day than our parents saw in their entire adolescence, and landfill sites are heaving with our cast-offs, we must question whether our progress in the pursuit of "modernity and visual democracy", is heading in the best direction.

If in this book – a truly definitive history of style and costume – the characters of the past seem quaint, think again. Many will have crafted a unique and individual garment for themselves to last for years, with patching and darning; others, in employing a local garment maker to create a bespoke and individual item, have addressed both sustainability and fair-trade issues. All that and no accompanying body image anxieties.

As I write, activists and MPs are battling against throwaway consumer culture. A garment made to fit and last, with full disclosure of materials and processes, and the maker taking responsibility for the continued life of the product to prevent landfill, must become the norm. Of comfort is the number of influential designers, covered within, who care about this too. While the craft of making must go hand in hand with environmental and social accountability, sustainability agendas must also address emotional and psychological landscapes to reflect the needs of a diverse audience. Many in fashion have been agitating for size, race, and age representation as a starting point, and new body-scanning technology offers hope for better fit and recognition of demographic needs. I have been thrilled to collaborate on this book to highlight the positive shift in identity politics, with the knowledge that there is more to come.

Combining a discussion of the role of clothes with the impact of future fashion industry processes is vital. With the help of social media, consumers can now mobilise behind brands with integrity and dismiss those without ethics. The power of the purse is one way to effectively shape our world. All this in the knowledge that our time could one day be condensed to a double-page spread and contextualised alongside the preceding eras in this book, is something we can each consider now.

Cathy Franklin ♥

